

A word of warning: You must be incredibly careful setting up an exchange. If the transaction has to be done at home, have a spouse or friend with you when the buyer arrives. Otherwise, I suggest that you meet in a public place for extra protection.

READER TIP:

Find the exact model you want, and set up alerts on Craigslist, then earmark a certain amount of money to be transferred into an online savings account each month. I did this last summer with our new couch. I originally planned on spending \$600, but (surprise!) paid only \$250 for a brand new couch with free delivery and takeaway.

—Kelsey, WA

2. SHOP USED RETAILERS

Surprisingly, thrift stores, consignment shops, and flea markets don't just sell worn out clothes and chintzy items—they almost always have a section of the store with used furniture. Not all items will be in perfect condition, but if you have a little imagination and a lot of paint, these beasts can quickly turn into bona fide beauties.

While searching online for kitchen counter stools, I found a gorgeous set that was the exact style and color I wanted, but they cost over \$100 apiece. I couldn't bring myself to buy them and instead, waited to see if anything close to what I was looking for popped up in our local thrift store. On a day when I least expected it, two beautiful stools arrived at \$20 each, and were almost identical to the ones I'd been eyeing. They weren't the exact color I wanted (black instead of white), but I knew painting them would be an easy fix.

Try to look past cosmetics on any piece, whether you pick it up at a thrift store or on the side of the road. You can almost always paint, refinish, or reupholster it. And if you need any newbie furniture makeover and finishing tips, you'll find a collection of helpful resources at